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Digital Literacy Project

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

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Introduction

This is the project report for CSE0001 Digital Literacy, submitted as part of the first year B.Tech program at VIT Bhopal. The project is built around the idea that I have been selected as a Student Digital Ambassador — someone whose job is to help batchmates figure out the digital world, from setting up professional profiles to staying safe online.

There are five tasks in total, each one tied to a different module of the course. I had to make a digital literacy infographic, build up my online presence on a few key platforms, try out some coding and collaboration tools, write professional emails, and research a cybercrime topic. All of it is organised in a GitHub repository which is part of the submission itself.

I will be honest — I did not expect to find this project as relevant as it turned out to be. Some of it, like the email etiquette task, feels like stuff I should have figured out already. Other parts, like the cybercrime research, genuinely changed how I think about things I do every day. This report goes through each task, what I did, and what I actually took away from it.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

What I Used

I used Canva for this. I had opened it a few times before but never really sat down and made anything properly. The tool is free, runs in the browser, and has enough templates that you can get something decent-looking fairly quickly even if you have no design background. That last part was pretty important for me.

What I Made

The infographic is called 'Digital Literacy: Skills Every Student Needs' and it covers three things — what digital literacy actually means, some basic safe internet habits, and a bit on why having a professional online presence matters. I kept it simple on purpose. Short headings, icons, and bullet points so someone could look at it for thirty seconds and still take something useful away. The target audience was basically my own batchmates, so I tried to make it feel relevant to us rather than generic.

What I Found Difficult — and Interesting

The hard part was narrowing it down. Digital literacy covers a lot of ground and I kept wanting to add more. Eventually I just had to accept that one page means one page and pick the three things that felt most immediately useful to a first year student. What I found genuinely interesting was realising that digital literacy is not really about knowing which apps exist. It is more about how you think when you use them — whether you are questioning what you read, protecting your own data, and

communicating in a way that reflects well on you. That reframe stuck with me. The final design is in the task-1-presentation/ folder.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms I Set Up

I set up accounts on GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. I had a basic GitHub account already but had never really done anything with it. LinkedIn I had heard about but kept putting off. Kaggle was completely new to me.

Platform	What it is actually for
GitHub	Storing and sharing code. Also where employers look when they want to see what you have actually built, not just what you claim on a resume.
LinkedIn	Professional networking. Finding internships, connecting with alumni, and building a presence that follows you into your career.
Kaggle	Data science and machine learning practice. Competitions, datasets, community notebooks — useful if you want to get into that space eventually.

What I Actually Did and What I Plan to Do

On GitHub I made a profile README with my name, branch, year, and a line about what I am hoping to learn. It felt a bit odd writing that when I am only in first year, but I get why it is useful — it is the start of a record that will build up over time. On LinkedIn I filled in my education section properly. On Kaggle I completed the basic profile setup.

None of these profiles are impressive yet and I am not going to pretend they are. But that is kind of the point of doing this in first year — starting before you have something to show, so that by the time you do have something to show, the foundation is already there. Over the next four years I want to use GitHub as a portfolio for actual projects, LinkedIn to connect with seniors and keep an eye on opportunities, and Kaggle to practice data skills as the coursework gets more technical. Screenshots are in task-2-portfolio/.

Task 3 – Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Part A – HackerRank

I signed up on HackerRank and completed the 'Solve Me First' beginner challenge. It is a very simple problem but that was not really the point. The point was getting familiar with how the platform works — submitting code, running it against test cases, seeing

the output. A lot of companies use HackerRank for placement tests so knowing the interface before you actually need it under pressure seems like a sensible thing to do. I am planning to spend more time on it once the semester settles down.

Part B – Google Forms Quiz

I built a five-question Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms. It has a mix of question types — at least one multiple choice and one short answer. The responses link automatically to a Google Sheet which is a feature I did not know about before this task. I tried to make the questions actually useful rather than just ticking a box, so someone who takes the quiz hopefully walks away knowing something they did not before. The form link is in the README.

What I Got Out of It

HackerRank is going to be directly relevant when placements come around, so starting early makes sense. Google Forms and Sheets I had used casually before but building something structured made me realise how much you can actually do with them. Both tools are free and browser-based which means no barriers to using them throughout the degree. Screenshots and the form link are in task-3-platforms/.

Task 4 – Professional Email & Etiquette Guide

The Two Emails

The first email is a student writing to their professor asking for an assignment deadline extension. The second is a student reaching out to an internship coordinator about a summer internship. Both follow the standard format — clear subject line, proper greeting, a body that gets to the point without being rude, and a sign-off that does not feel awkward.

The internship one was harder to write. When you are in first year with basically nothing to show yet, expressing 'interest' in an internship could easily come across as either desperate or completely unqualified. The trick is to be honest about where you are while still making a case for why giving you a shot is worth it. I think the draft I ended up with does that reasonably well.

Social Media Checklist

I also put together a do's and don'ts list for social media use as a college student. Five do's, five don'ts. Things like not sharing personal details publicly, not posting out of frustration about classmates or lecturers, and using privacy settings properly. The checklist is saved as social-media-checklist.md in the task-4-email-etiquette/ folder.

The Communication Scenario

There was a case I came across where a new employee posted complaints about their manager on a public Twitter account, assuming their account was private. It was not. Colleagues and HR saw it, and the fallout affected their position at the company. What makes that story stick is how ordinary the mistake was. They were not trying to cause trouble — they were just venting, the same way everyone does with friends. The difference was the platform and the audience, and they had not thought about either. The lesson I take from it is that anything you post in anger, you should wait at least a day before actually posting.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study

What I Chose and Why

I went with UPI and online payment fraud for the case study. Partly because it is the most common type of cybercrime that affects people my age in India right now, and partly because it felt more immediately relevant than something like ransomware which is more of a corporate threat. The full case study is in task-5-cybercrime/casestudy.md.

How It Actually Works

The basic pattern is this: someone gets a message that looks official — could be WhatsApp, could be email — claiming their bank account has a problem that needs immediate attention. There is a link, there is urgency, and the website the link goes to looks almost identical to the real bank's website. The person enters their OTP or UPI PIN thinking they are verifying their account. The money is gone in minutes. The whole thing is engineered around two things: urgency and appearance. Take away either of those and most people would catch it. But together they are very effective.

What Surprised Me and What I Am Changing

The thing that actually surprised me was how good the fake websites look. I had always imagined phishing attempts as obviously suspicious — bad grammar, weird logos, something clearly off. Some of the real examples I found while researching this looked completely legitimate. I would not have caught them without specifically checking the URL, which is not something I always do.

As a result of this task I have turned on transaction alerts on all my UPI apps and I am going to make a habit of checking the sender address on any email that asks me to do something urgently. Small things, but they cover the most common ways this kind of fraud actually works. The prevention checklist with eight specific tips — including two on UPI safety and the reporting channels cybercrime.gov.in and 1930 — is in task-5-cybercrime/prevention-checklist.md.

Conclusion

Going into this project I thought it would mostly be box-ticking. Set up some accounts, write some emails, submit the repo. It ended up being more useful than that. The infographic task made me think about what digital literacy actually means beyond just knowing which apps exist. Setting up the profiles made me think about what I am building over time and whether I am being honest about where I am. The cybercrime research genuinely changed some daily habits. And the email task reminded me that how you say something matters as much as what you are saying, especially when you need something from someone.

None of this is complicated in theory. The tricky part is actually applying it consistently — pausing before posting, checking before clicking, thinking about who is reading before sending. That gap between knowing something and doing it is probably the most honest takeaway from this whole project.

References

- Canva – canva.com
- GitHub – github.com
- LinkedIn – linkedin.com
- Kaggle – kaggle.com
- HackerRank – hackerrank.com
- Google Forms – forms.google.com
- National Cyber Crime Portal – cybercrime.gov.in
- Cyber Crime Helpline – 1930 (Government of India, 24x7)